LESSON 10

Wake Up *Your Mind*

Cognitive Exercises & Brain Health in Parkinson's

Cognitive Impairment in Parkinson's

What is cognitive impairment? A broad term referring to difficulties with **memory, thinking, concentration,** and other brain functions.

These challenges are greater than normal aging and can be difficult to manage with current medical therapies alone.

Memory

Thinking & Focus

Mental Clarity

Common in Parkinson's disease — and can significantly affect quality of life.

But here's the good news →

Exercise is one of the most *powerful tools* we have to support brain function.

Research shows that problem solving, memory, and focus can improve immediately following exercise.

How Exercise Boosts Your Brain

Regular exercise releases powerful brain chemicals and stimulates key memory structures:

BDNF

Brain-Derived Neurotrophic Factor

Supports memory, learning, concentration & overall brain health. Released during regular physical activity.

Hippocampus

Key area for learning & memory

Responds strongly to aerobic exercise. Can actually grow stronger as you become more physically fit.

After You Exercise, Your Brain Thanks You

Have you ever noticed that after you exercise you feel lighter — not just in your body, but in your mind?

Clearer Thoughts

Your mind cuts through brain fog and processes information faster

Better Attention

Moderate aerobic activity improves both focus and concentration

Stronger Memory

Problem solving and remembering information improves post-exercise

More Energy

You feel energized and ready to do more — body and mind

That's your brain responding to movement.

Brain Games: Fun, But Not Enough

What Apps CAN Do

- Fun and stimulating
- Improve skill at that specific game
- Keep the mind engaged

True Cognitive Improvement

Comes when the brain is challenged in many different ways — not just one game or skill.

That's where exercise becomes so powerful.

When physical movement meets cognitive challenge, multiple areas of the brain light up at the same time.

Body + Mind: Our Approach in Class

We intentionally incorporate exercises that challenge both the body and the mind at the same time.

The Dot-to-Dot Challenge

Fighters completed a numbered puzzle before class — then the exact same puzzle immediately after. Every single person beat their original time.

Flashcard Math While Moving

Volunteers walk around with flashcards containing math problems. Fighters solve them while exercising — a whole new level of multitasking.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Challenge yourself both physically and *mentally.*

Nutrition matters too

Prioritize both exercise and a healthy diet — you'll always be one step ahead.

Build your wiggle room

Tougher days will come — be two steps ahead, not three steps behind.